

What to do See your doctor, who will rule out other causes for the abdominal pain. Once you have been reassured, you should find it easier to deal with the pain. When you have an episode, try to rest and relax. Lying on your side and bringing your knees up toward your chest may be helpful, as can taking a warm bath.

Sciatica is pain in one or both buttocks that may radiate down one leg. In a small percentage of women, a tingling or numbness in the legs may also occur. Sciatica is most likely to occur after the second trimester.

Causes Sciatica is caused by trapping or compression of the sciatic nerve as it runs through the spinal column. The pain is termed referred pain, as it is felt in an area away from the problem site. Sciatica is not caused by compression of the nerve by the fetus's head. The causes of sciatica in pregnancy are the same as in women who are not pregnant and include poor posture, wear and tear on vertebral joints, and poor lifting techniques.

What to do Specific exercises can help to stretch muscles gently and release pressure on the sciatic nerve. Your doctor may be able to advise you on exercises or may refer you to a physical therapist for help.

Coccygeal pain The coccyx, or tailbone, is the small bone found at the base of the spine. This bone is usually fairly immobile; however, in pregnancy it becomes more mobile, which facilitates the passage of the baby through the birth canal during labor. Pain in this area can make sitting for long periods extremely uncomfortable, particularly at work or during travel. Coccygeal pain can occur throughout pregnancy.

Causes Coccygeal pain may predate pregnancy due to a previous injury to the area; the discomfort may then be exacerbated by the hormonal and mechanical changes of pregnancy. Alternatively, coccygeal pain may arise, as increased movement in the coccyx during this time makes injury more likely. Sometimes the coccyx is injured during labor by the baby's head, and coccygeal pain therefore develops after the birth.

What to do Moving around frequently and gently massaging the area can help relieve discomfort. Ask your doctor which analgesics are safe for you to take. The condition usually gets better within 6 weeks of delivery.

Leg cramps Cramps in the legs, particularly in the calf muscles, are a common problem during pregnancy. These leg cramps occur most commonly at night but may sometimes come on when walking, and their frequency can increase as your pregnancy advances.

Causes There is debate as to the cause of leg cramps in pregnancy. They are likely to be caused by a combination of factors, including maternal posture, increasing body weight, restriction in the blood flow to the legs, and the pressure of the uterus on the pelvic nerves. Some suggest that leg cramps in pregnancy may be due to a lack of salt in the diet. However, research demonstrates that low levels of salt are healthy in pregnancy, and that it is very unlikely that anyone who is eating a balanced diet will suffer from salt depletion.

What to do Leg cramps may be relieved by changing position, flexing the toes of the affected leg upward, and massaging the cramped muscle. To avoid leg cramps, massage your legs before bed and avoid sitting or standing in one position for long periods. A warm bath before bed may also help. Stay well hydrated and alternate regular periods of moderate exercise with periods of rest.

If you have persistent pain, redness, or swelling in your calf, this may be a sign of [deep vein thrombosis \(DVT\)](#), which requires prompt medical attention.

Restless legs syndrome This is an uncomfortable feeling or unpleasant tingling that creates an overwhelming desire to move your legs, or causes legs to jerk uncontrollably, especially during sleep. Sufferers describe the sensation as being like an electric current passing through the legs or like having itchy bones. It is most likely to occur during the third trimester.